Building Dad's Application-Ready File a Category at a Time

Your family's part, in order, with a line for who does each action and by when.

The goal: Dad's records are organized where the family can find them, the larger money events are written down while people remember them, and your family knows who would handle an application and whom you'd call.

One category this month and another the next gets it done. Put a name beside each action. “By when” can be a month or a season; nothing on this page has a deadline.

ACTION	WHO	BY WHEN	DONE
1. Ask Dad whether he's willing to do this together, and choose with him one place for the file: a box, a drawer, a folder on his computer.			
2. Find his identity and residency papers, and any care or medical paperwork worth keeping with them. Note where each is kept.			
3. Organize his Social Security and income records.			
4. Organize his bank statements: where they're kept, on paper or online, and where new ones go as they arrive.			
5. Organize his investment and retirement-account records the same way.			
6. Organize his insurance records, policy by policy.			
7. Organize his property records: the deed to his home, and the papers for any other property.			
8. Organize any trust and annuity papers, and, if Dad is married, keep his spouse's financial records organized the same way.			
9. Start a dated list of significant financial transactions, and of any gifts or transfers, with whatever paperwork exists. Write what happened. Don't judge it, and don't change or undo anything.			
10. Write down who would be responsible for completing an eventual application, and which professional your family would contact.			

ACTION	WHO	BY WHEN	DONE
11. Write down your questions for a professional: which program would likely apply, where applications are submitted, and which documentation problems can delay one.			
12. Put a date on the file, and choose when you'll update it.			

You're done when

Dad's records are organized in one place the family can find, the larger money events are written down with their paperwork, and your family knows who would handle an application and whom you'd call when the time comes. What comes after that, the review of the file, the question of whether and when to apply, and the application itself, isn't on this list, because it isn't the family's to do alone.

If a month gets away from you

- Don't fill a gap by guessing. “Haven't found it yet” is a finished line.
- If Dad would rather stop for now, stop. The file will keep.
- If a question comes up about what a sale, a gift or an account means, write it down for a professional and carry on with the list.

What this plan doesn't do

It organizes your family's part. It doesn't say which records Dad's state requires or how far back, determine eligibility, decide whether or when to apply, or stand in for the professional review it prepares you for. Rules vary by state; bring those questions to your Medicaid planner or the appropriate licensed professional. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You've worked down the list a category at a time, and the file has a date on it. The planning interview goes on from there: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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